COGNITIVE NEUROSCIENCE

The Organized Mind

Thinking Straight in the Age of Information Overload

Daniel J. Levitin · 2014

A neuroscientist explains how attention and memory actually work, then shows how to organize your home, your time and your decisions around their limits.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- A clear tour of how your attention system works [3,4]
- Practical advice for homes, time, work and big decisions [1,5]
- A brilliant appendix on thinking clearly about risk [1,5]



GET THE BOOK

The Organized Mind by Daniel J. Levitin
Dutton (Penguin), 2014. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *The Organized Mind* by Daniel J. Levitin. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Get it out of your head

Conscious attention can only handle a small amount of information at a time; Levitin estimates around 120 bits per second. Every open loop you hold in your head competes for that space. Moving information into the world, into places and systems you trust, frees your mind to think.[1,6]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Multitasking is switching**
   We don't really do two things at once. We switch rapidly, and every switch costs energy and adds errors.[6,7]

2. **Give things a home**
   Designated places for things you often lose, like a hook for your keys, let the environment do the remembering.[5]

3. **Good enough is often best**
   For small decisions, satisfice: accept good enough and save your effort for the choices that matter. The idea comes from Herbert Simon.[7,8]

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THE FRAMEWORK

How attention works[3,5]

Levitin describes several parts of the attentional system. Knowing them explains why focus slips.[3,5]

1 Mind-wandering mode

The daydreaming brain

A loose, associative state where ideas connect and the brain rests.[3]

Try: Protect time with no input at all.

2 Central executive

The focused brain

The mode for deliberate work. It and mind-wandering tend to switch each other off.[3,5]

Try: Give it one thing at a time.

3 Attentional filter

What gets through

Screens the flood of input so only some reaches awareness.[3,5]

Try: Cut low-value inputs at the source.

4 Attentional switch

Moving between modes

Shifts you between focus and wandering. Each switch has a cost.[3,6]

Try: Batch similar tasks together.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

Index-card capture

Levitin's low-tech system for open loops.[3,5]

1. Write each task or idea on its own card.
2. Sort the cards each day: do now, and later.
3. Re-sort as priorities change.

The fourfold table

From the book's appendix, for reasoning about risk.[1,5]

1. Draw a 2 by 2 grid: test result against actual condition.
2. Fill it with counts per 1,000 people.
3. Read off the real chance that a positive result means you have the condition.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Spend five minutes writing every open loop, one per card or note.
2. Sort them into now and later.
3. Give one thing you often lose a fixed home.
4. Batch your replies into one block a day.

REFLECT

What are you holding in your head that could live somewhere else?

Where in your day do you switch most often?

Try it in Sedi: Brain-dump onto the Universal Board, one card per thought, then drag each to Taskly, Timely or Brainly.

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🗂️ The Organized Mind

Daniel J. Levitin · Dutton (Penguin) · 2014

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Daniel J. Levitin or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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